

which in itself is quite the powerful tool. It features an easy-to-use interface, where you can “paint” on the different tracks of your music, time-stretch it on the fly and create impeccable loops. It even has a bunch of how-to tutorials when it starts up to show you just what you can do with it. Sure, it does nag you to buy the paid versions for the cooler features, but this one still wins some kudos as is.

FL Studio 6.0

Formerly FruityLoops, it’s no wonder that the word “Studio” had to be added to the name—FL Studio has always been a favourite with those interested in creating their own dance music tracks. While it started out primarily as a software to create music loops, it’s now a full-blown music mixer, complete with effects processors and other



FL Studio—still quite fruity

bells and whistles. You’ll be able to create some semblance of music within the first minute of your session—that’s how easy it is to use. All you need to know is that unlike many editors today that let you place sound clips on a timeline, here you enable or disable them using on-off switches that determine when a sound is going to be played. Though still quite heavily geared towards the creation of new music rather than mixing existing sound, it’s quite an amazing tool. It even supports the open VST architecture, so you can keep adding plugins whenever you want. And if all that weren’t enough, Blake Reary’s *Hanging On*, recorded exclusively for FL Studio in FL Studio is one of the most addictive tracks we’ve heard in a while.

Cubase

Steinberg Audio’s (the creators of the VST open architecture) flagship product, Cubase, had been much abused for its CPU-hogging capabilities, but Steinberg cleaned up their act and Cubase is now one of the fastest mixing programs out there, even on compara-